First steps

Five-finger positions, steady beats, and your first real tunes.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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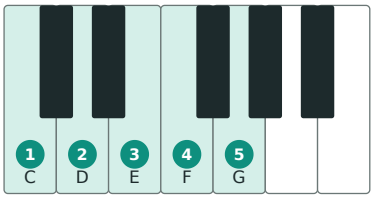
1. Right hand C position

One finger per key, thumb on Middle C.

Five fingers, five keys

Put your right thumb (1) on **Middle C**. Let the other fingers rest on the next white keys: 2 on D, 3 on E, 4 on F, 5 on G.

This is the **C position**. Each finger has its own key, so you never have to look for notes. Keep that bubble shape!

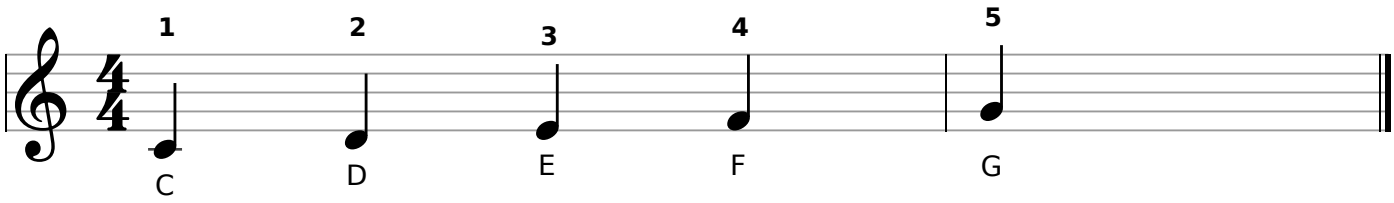


Right hand C position: thumb on Middle C

Figure 2.1 · Five fingers, five keys

Practise · Up the C position

Play C D E F G with fingers 1 2 3 4 5. Slow and even, like footsteps.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · And back down

Now come back down: G F E D C, fingers 5 4 3 2 1.

Practise · Up and down together

Put it together without stopping. Listen for every note sounding equally loud.

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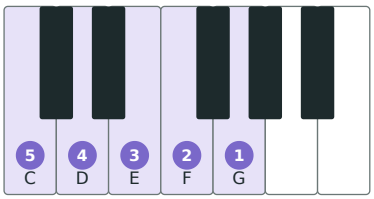
2. Left hand C position

The mirror image: pinky on C.

The left hand

Your left hand is a mirror image. Place your **left pinky (5)** on the C **below** Middle C. Then 4 on D, 3 on E, 2 on F and thumb (1) on G.

So going up the keys, the left hand counts **5 4 3 2 1**. That feels strange at first. Go slowly.

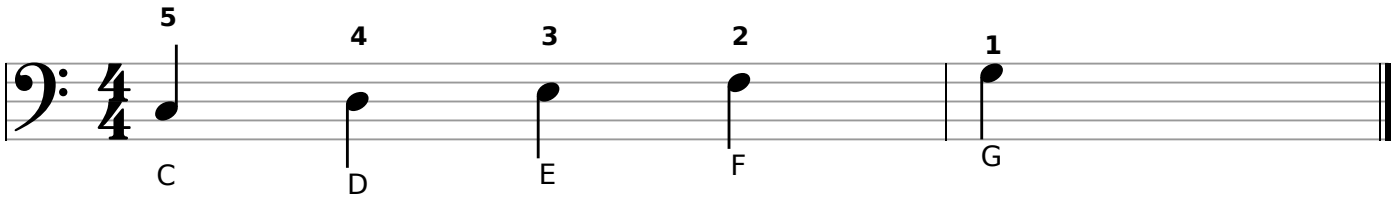


t hand C position: pinky on the C below Middl

Figure 2.2 · The left hand

Practise · Left hand up

Play C D E F G with left-hand fingers 5 4 3 2 1.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand down

And back down, fingers 1 2 3 4 5.

Practise · Pinky and thumb

Bounce between your outside fingers: C and G, then the middle, E.

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3. Steady beats

Quarter, half and whole notes.

Music has a pulse

Under all music there's a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat or a clock ticking. Notes last for a number of beats:

- **Quarter note**: 1 beat
- **Half note**: 2 beats
- **Whole note**: 4 beats

In this app, longer notes show as wider boxes. Count out loud: "one, two, three, four".

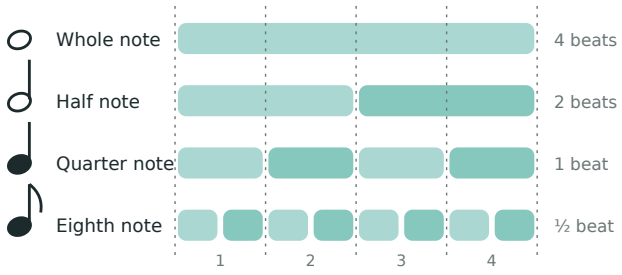
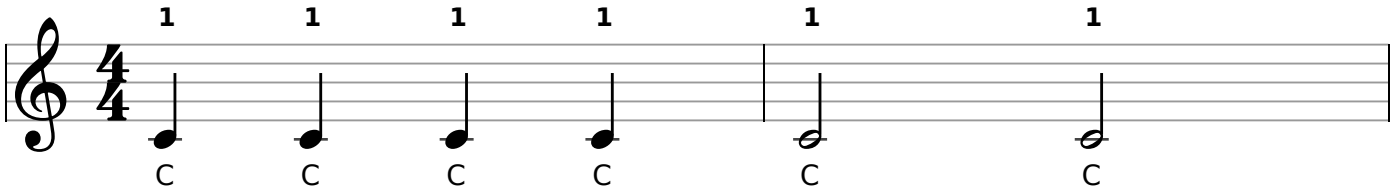


Figure 2.3 · Music has a pulse

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. How many beats does each note last?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** 2 beats Those were half notes: two beats each.

Practise · Counting while you play

Tap "Listen" first to hear the rhythm, then play it on Middle C, counting out loud.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Mixing lengths

Hold the wide notes longer. Count "1 2 3 4" in every group.

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4. Steps and skips

How notes move: next door, or jumping over one.

Moving by step or skip

When a melody moves to the very next key, that's a **step** (like C to D). When it jumps over one key, that's a **skip** (like C to E).

In C position, a step uses the next finger, and a skip skips a finger.

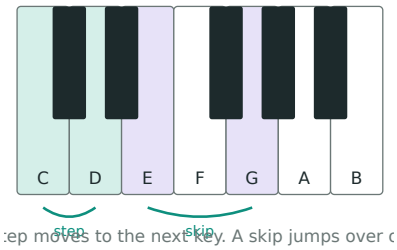
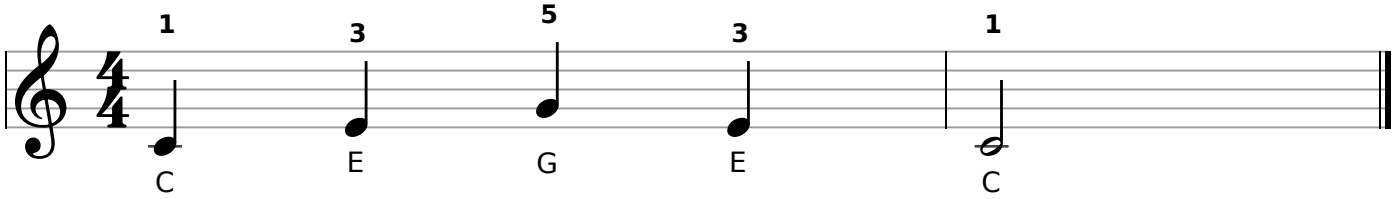


Figure 2.4 · Moving by step or skip

Practise · Skipping up

Play C, E, G with fingers 1, 3, 5, then back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Did the melody move by steps or by skips?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Steps C, D, E, F: each note is next door to the last.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Skips C, E, G: every note skipped over one.

Practise · Steps and skips mixed

Watch the fingers: some steps, some skips.

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5. First tune: Hot Cross Buns

Three notes, one happy song.

Your first song

This old street-seller's song uses just three notes: **E D C**, played with fingers 3 2 1. The fast notes in the middle are **eighth notes**, two per beat.

Tap **Listen** to hear it first. Then play along at your own speed.

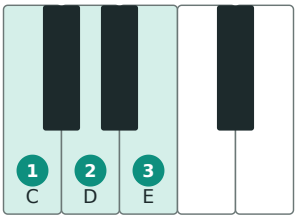


Figure 2.5 · Your first song

Practise · Hot Cross Buns

Right hand in C position. Go slowly. The app waits for you.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

6. Lightly Row

A rowing song that walks up and down C position.

Lightly Row

This German children's song is called **Hänschen klein** at home, and **Lightly Row** in English. It fits your C position exactly: thumb on Middle C, finger 5 on G.

Each line starts with a skip down from G to E, then a step down to D and C. Listen for the pattern and it will play itself.

Practise · First verse

Thumb on Middle C. G, E, E; F, D, D; then walk up C D E F G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lightly Row

The whole song. The middle part repeats D, then E, then climbs to G.

7. Mary Had a Little Lamb

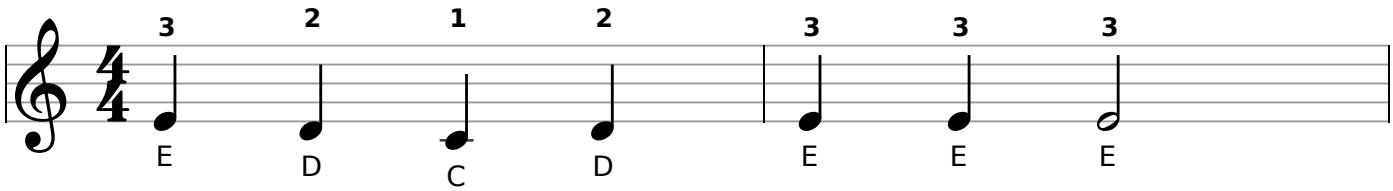
Four fingers and a skip up to G.

A longer tune

This melody uses **C D E** plus a skip up to **G** with your pinky. Keep your hand in C position the whole time and the notes are always under your fingers.

Practise · Mary Had a Little Lamb

Play the whole tune. Notice the long note at the end: hold it for four beats.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

8. Doxology: the second line

Add "Praise Him, all creatures here below" to the line you know.

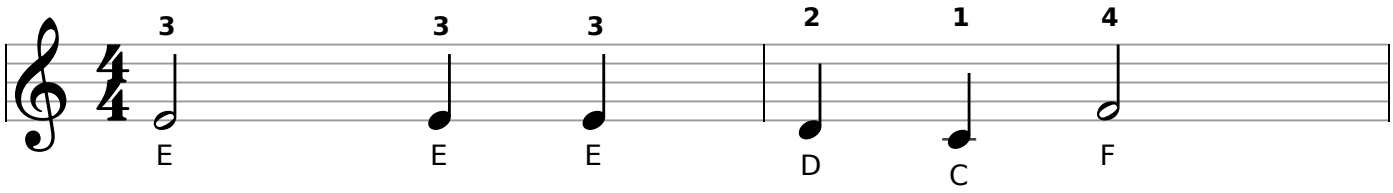
The Doxology grows

Your first recital was the opening line of the **Doxology**. In every unit from now on you'll add a little more, until you can play the whole hymn with both hands.

Line two, **"Praise Him, all creatures here below"**, starts on E with three in a row, steps down to C, then jumps up to F and steps back down.

Practise · Line 2

Thumb on Middle C, so finger 3 is on E. Three Es, then D, C, a little jump to F, and back down E, D.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Start with finger 4 on Middle C as before. After "flow", move your hand so your thumb is on C again for line two.

9. Sleep, Baby, Sleep

A gentle German lullaby in C position.

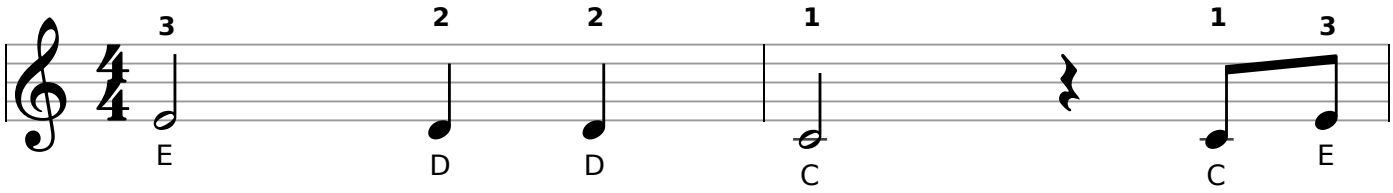
A lullaby

Schlaf, Kindlein, schlaf ("Sleep, baby, sleep") is a German lullaby that has been sung for over 200 years. Play it softly and slowly, as if someone is falling asleep.

Look out for the **two quick notes** after the first rest: C and E, twice as fast as a quarter note, leading into the high G.

Practise · Sleep, Baby, Sleep

Thumb on Middle C. Softly. Count the rests: they are part of the music.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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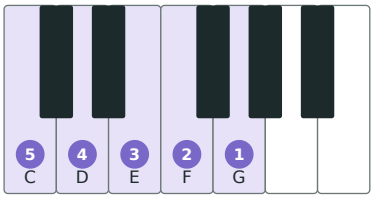
10. Left hand tune: Au Clair de la Lune

A French folk song for your left hand.

Left hand leads

Melodies aren't only for the right hand. Place your left hand in C position (pinky on the C below Middle C) and play this gentle French song.

Remember: on the left hand, C is finger **5**, D is **4**, E is **3**.

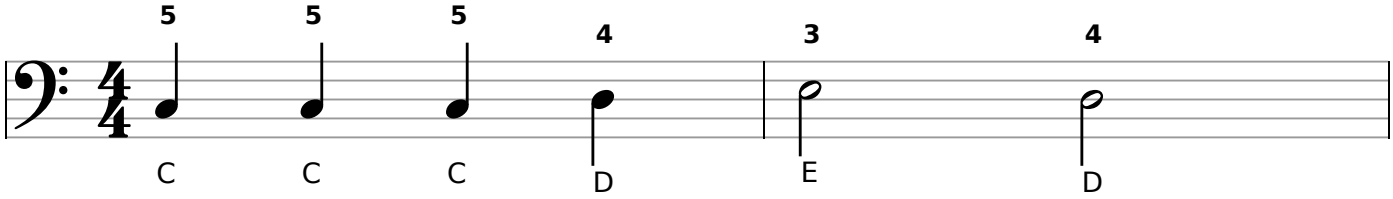


t hand C position: pinky on the C below Middl

Figure 2.6 · Left hand leads

Practise · Au Clair de la Lune

Left hand only. Let it sing, softly and smoothly.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

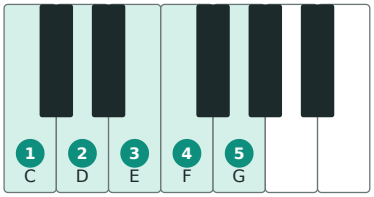
11. Ode to Joy (right hand)

Beethoven's famous melody, in C position.

Beethoven!

This melody is from Beethoven's **Ninth Symphony** (1824), one of the most famous pieces ever written. And it fits perfectly in your right-hand C position.

It has two halves that are almost the same. Only the ending is different. Watch for the **dotted** note near the end of each half: it lasts a beat and a half.



Right hand C position: thumb on Middle C

Figure 2.7 · Beethoven!

Practise · First half

Play the first half. Fingers on C D E F G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half

Same start, but this time it ends on C, home.

Practise · The whole melody

Both halves without stopping. You are playing Beethoven!

12. All My Little Ducklings

A German children's song with a small hand shift.

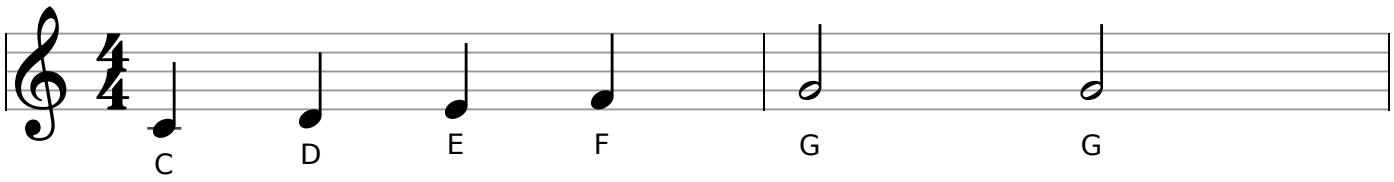
Alle meine Entchen

Every German child learns **Alle meine Entchen**: "All my little ducklings swimming on the lake, heads down in the water, tails up in the air."

It walks up C D E F G, then needs one note beyond C position: **A**. Start with thumb 1 on Middle C and play C D E F G G using 1 2 3 4 5 5. Release the second G and move your whole hand one white key right: thumb on D, pinky on A. Play the As with 5 and the Gs with 4. Stay in this position for F E D with 3 2 1, then release and move your thumb back to Middle C for the ending. Practise the moves silently first; pause freely and keep the hand relaxed.

Practise · All My Little Ducklings

C position first. After G G, release and move to D position for the As. Use 3 2 1 for F E D, then release and return your thumb to C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

13. One hand holds while the other moves

Give each hand a different job, one small pattern at a time.

Tap before you play

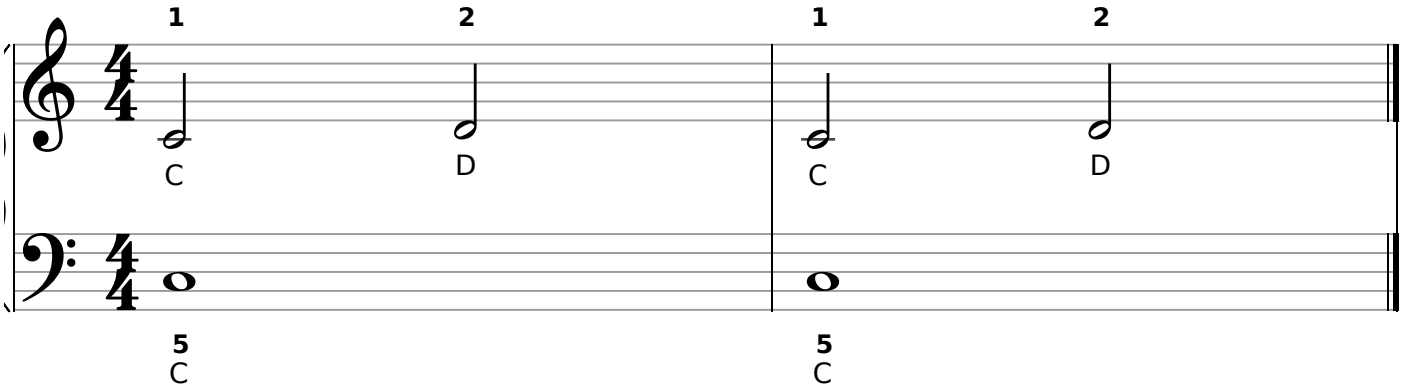
Tap four steady beats with your right hand on your knee. Rest your left hand on the other knee and keep it still for all four beats. Repeat, lifting and replacing the left hand only on beat 1. Say “hold, hold, hold” as the right hand continues.

At the piano, your left pinky will hold C below Middle C while the right hand plays separate notes. Let the left key stay down; do not squeeze it harder each time the right hand moves. Use no pedal so you can hear an early release.

The microphone checks the note starts. It cannot confirm that you kept the bass down: listen for that yourself. If it stalls on an octave pair, use Easy chords while continuing to play both hands; the assisted result is separate from your own listening check.

Practise · Two moving notes over one bass

Left pinky on C below Middle C. Play it with right thumb on Middle C. Keep the left C held for four beats while the right hand plays C for two beats, then D for two. Release together.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Four notes over a held C

Left C lasts the whole bar. Right hand plays C D E D, one note per beat. Listen to the bass throughout; it should not stop between right-hand notes.

Practise · Change the bass on beat one

Hold left C for the first bar and left G for the second. The right hand continues C D E D, then E D C C. Prepare the left change during the long note; release the old bass as you play the new one.

Listen for independence

Try one bar without looking at the screen. Was the bass continuous? Were the right-hand notes even? Did your shoulders stay loose? If one hand copied the other, return to the knee-tapping pattern before playing again.

Now the Hands together lesson will connect these small patterns to a familiar melody. Use separate-hand practice and a slow tempo whenever the jobs become tangled.

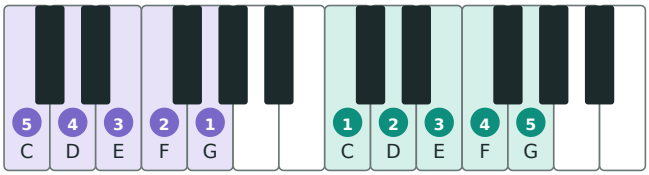
14. Hands together

Both hands at once, starting simple.

Two hands, one brain

Playing with both hands is the big step that makes the piano sound like a piano. Start with both hands in C position, an octave (eight notes) apart.

When both hands play the **same letters** together, your left hand uses 5 4 3 2 1 while your right uses 1 2 3 4 5. Go very slowly; the app waits until it hears both notes.

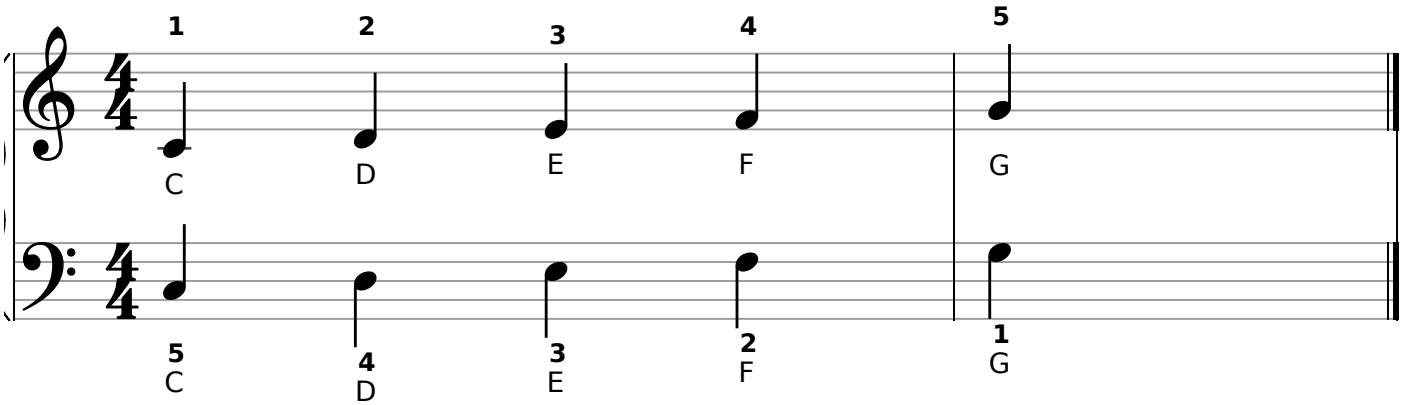


Both hands in C position

Figure 2.8 · Two hands, one brain

Practise · Both hands up

Play C with both hands together (left 5, right 1), then D, E, F, G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Both hands down

And back down together.

Melody and bass

Usually the right hand plays the **melody** while the left hand plays slower, lower **bass** notes underneath.

Next you'll play Ode to Joy with a single left-hand note at the start of each group of four beats: just C or G. Hold the left note while the right hand keeps going.

Practise · Ode to Joy, hands together

Left hand plays C (finger 5) or G (finger 1) and holds it. Right hand plays the melody.

15. Au Clair de la Lune, hands together

The French tune in your right hand, with a left-hand bass.

Melody and bass

You played **Au Clair de la Lune** with your left hand. Now the right hand takes the tune, and the left hand plays long low notes underneath: **C** with finger 5 and **G** with your thumb.

The left hand only moves on beats 1 and 3. Play the tune twice: the second time, the words are "prête-moi ta plume".

Practise · Left hand alone

Pinky on the C below Middle C. C, then C and G, C and G, and C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Au Clair de la Lune, hands together

Both hands. The left hand holds its notes while the right hand sings.

16. Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee

The hymn set to Beethoven's Ode to Joy, with both hands.

A hymn from Beethoven

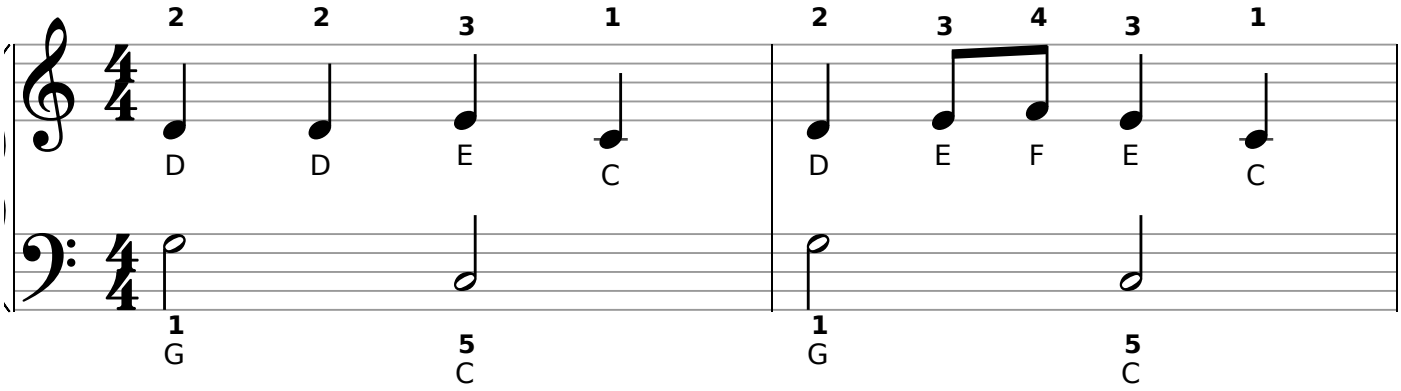
In 1907 Henry van Dyke wrote the words **"Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee"** to fit Beethoven's Ode to Joy melody. It's now one of the best-loved hymns in the world.

The hymn has four lines. You already know three of them! The new one is the **third line**, which bounces between D and E and has quick eighth notes.

At the end of that line the melody dips to a low G. Your **left-hand thumb** plays it, since it's sitting right there.

Practise · The new middle line

Right hand. Watch the quick F between the Es. The left thumb plays the final low G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal

All four lines, both hands, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

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17. When the Saints Go Marching In

A lively spiritual in C position, with rests to count.

When the Saints Go Marching In

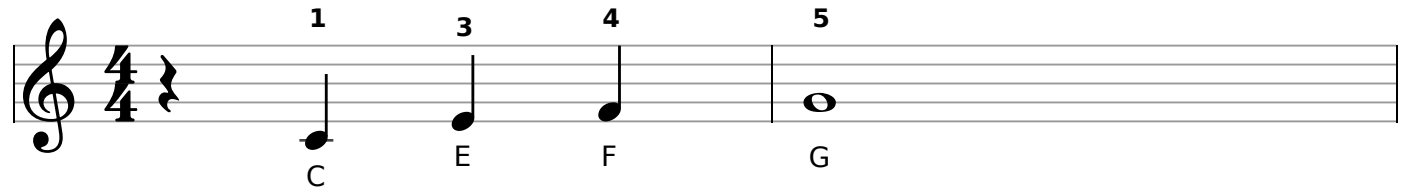
This African-American spiritual became the anthem of **New Orleans** jazz bands. It's bright, bouncy and fun to play.

It sits entirely in **C position**: thumb on Middle C, one finger per key up to G.

Most lines start with a **rest**: a silent beat. Count "1" in your head, then play on "2 3 4". The long notes are **whole notes**: hold them for four beats.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"Oh when the saints go marching in…" Rest on beat 1, then C E F and a long G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

"Oh Lord, I want to be in that number…" and home to C.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole song, with hints. Keep the beat steady through the rests.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Find C position with either hand without labelled keys.
- ☐ Keep a steady beat while playing steps and skips.
- ☐ Play a familiar melody with the suggested fingers.
- ☐ Practise each hand separately, then bring both hands together slowly.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
